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Brian Goldsmith's Senate Bid Rooted in Fighting Antisemitism in California

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Long active in Jewish advocacy and pro-Israel politics, the Democratic strategist and former journalist says combating antisemitism will be central to his campaign for California's 24th State Senate District.

Brian Goldsmith was not an elected official when antisemitism bill AB 715 came up for a vote in the California Legislature. He was a private citizen, but lobbied anyway — reaching out personally to undecided legislators and advocating for protections for Jewish students on campus.

Now, in a bid for California's 24th District State Senate seat currently held by Democrat Ben Allen, Goldsmith is seeking a title to underscore his fight against anti-Jewish discrimination.

Long before the violence of Oct. 7, 2023 touched every corner of the Jewish consciousness, Brian Goldsmith had already decided that antisemitism inside the Democratic Party — and beyond — was an issue worth the political risk. He became the first senior adviser to Democratic Majority for Israel PAC, helping elect pro-Israel politicians to Congress and winning more than 80% of races.

Goldsmith spent his career as a journalist, entrepreneur and Harvard and Stanford Law graduate learning how to turn complexity into action, but his Jewish values remain the throughline.

"I have been focused on protecting Israel and taking on the battle against antisemitism for much of my life. I am fortunate to have been raised in a strong Jewish family that is deeply engaged in this cause," Goldsmith said.

Goldsmith was raised in a family deeply involved in Jewish philanthropy. His maternal grandfather, Jerry Mack, served as chairman of the Israel Bonds Campaign, founded Temple Beth Sholom in Las Vegas, and received the Israel Prime Minister's Medal in 1973. He also attended the Camp David Accords signing ceremony as a guest of President Carter.

His paternal grandparents, Bram and Elaine Goldsmith, were lead contributors to the Jewish Federation's Goldsmith Center and supporters of the Weizmann Institute of Science.

Those roots in Jewish advocacy are why, for Brian Goldsmith, running for State Senate is not a career pivot, but a continuation of a generational pursuit.

"Representation is about who is present when decisions are made. Brian is stepping forward with clarity, discipline, and a lifetime of preparation," Jewish journalist and philanthropist Jacki Karsh said.

The endorsements following Goldsmith's Senate announcement reflect support beyond standard political alignment. Along with Democratic figures including Nancy Pelosi, Hillary Clinton and Pete Buttigieg, the California Legislative Jewish Caucus endorsed him. So did Julie Platt, former chair of the Jewish Federations of North America.

State Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), who authored AB 715, noted Goldsmith's record of Jewish activism.

"Even as a private citizen, he jumped in to lobby members to help us pass landmark antisemitism legislation ... I am grateful for his advice and wisdom and look forward to working with him after he wins," Gabriel said.

While he is a critic of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, Goldsmith remains unwavering in his support for the

State of Israel — the state his grandparents supported in its infancy.

"I cannot imagine a world without Israel and will never abandon our commitment to Israel's security," he said. "I have fought against any effort to single out Israel for unique condemnation or to apply a different standard to the world's only Jewish state."

He is drawing support from across the political spectrum.

"While our politics may sometimes differ, I know he would be a strong ally for our community in the legislature. He is passionate about tackling hate and division," Jewish entrepreneur Michael Broukhim said.

Brian Goldsmith, his wife Claire, and their two children live in California's 24th Senate District, which includes Brentwood, Pacific Palisades, Beverly Hills, West Hollywood and Sherman Oaks.

The district has experienced a rise in antisemitic incidents since Oct. 7, but Goldsmith projects confidence in his Judaism and a sense of resolve.

"Antisemitism is not a policy disagreement," he said. "It would be unacceptable against any group — any group, that is, except, sometimes, the Jewish community. And that is a double standard we have to fight and defeat."

Goldsmith intends to join the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, a body of lawmakers focused on the needs of the state's Jewish community.

"I'd aim to be a leader and a go-to voice, especially on combating antisemitism and hate in all forms," Goldsmith said. "I say every day, to every group, that antisemitism — and the broader epidemic of hate and division — is one of the most significant challenges we face …"

He also believes in supporting Jewish nonprofits, noting their broader role in public life.

"They are a beacon of tolerance and acceptance, they deserve security and protection against hate and harassment, and they play a critical role delivering public services beyond the Jewish community," he said.

The California Legislature lacks voices who understand that defending the Jewish community is not a partisan act, but a moral one.

"We need to take on forces that foment division and antisemitism and hold them to a higher standard — even if Washington won't," he said. "When hate rears its ugly head against one ethnicity, it hurts us all, and we must work to stand united."

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